

25 Country Licks You Should Know, Part 1

every player can learn from these pearls of twang

A well-rounded player knows the basics of country guitar, so even if your tastes and professional duties have little to do with straight country, it pays to try your hand at the techniques developed by generations of C&W players. Studying the great country guitarists can improve your speed, tone, taste, intonation, and accuracy, regardless of your chosen style. This time out we'll look at the first dozen of the 25 must-know country licks; next issue we'll do the rest.

As you play these licks, vary the rhythms and dynamics. Accent different notes and put the excerpts in various contexts. Try them with and without effects (light compression, subtle slapback delay, and reverb are common effects in use on today's recordings). And since you'll want to use light-gauge strings to get some of the bends, be careful not to set your tone too thin. Most

By Joe Dalton

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important, feel the phrases. Get past the literal notation—make your guitar sing, laugh, and cry.

Straight from country's roots, **Ex. 1a** is a bluegrass staple usually played with strict alternate picking. Try this lick both with and without the hammer-ons and pull-offs. **Ex. 1b** is the same lick in closed position, transposed up one and two octaves. Aside from the chromatic passing tones, the lick follows the G-major pentatonic scale. Many country solos, intros, and endings use this lick forwards and backwards; you'll find nice versions of it in Dwight Yoakam's "Guitars, Cadillacs," Arthur "Guitar Boogie" Smith's "Guitar Boogie Shuffle," and Albert Lee's "Country Boy."

Grady Martin's smooth, flowing lines helped make Marty Robbins' "El Paso" a

gigantic hit. **Ex. 2** tries to capture some of that flavor. The *D* and *Em* arpeggios and the use of thirds impart a strong Tex-Mex flavor. Notice how the *B* and *D* notes in bar 3 create a little tension before resolving to the chordal tones *A* and *C#* on the fifth beat. Also note the major-7th sound in bar 5. Play the example with a strong sense of three (1-2-3, 4-5-6). The first three beats of measure 5 are played with a fast mandolin-style tremolo.

Pick and fingers

Many country guitarists use some combination of pick and fingers; **Ex. 3**, the sort of thing Jimmy Colvard plays on Dave Dudley's "Six Days On The Road," is a good look at the technique. Use your pick on the fifth and fourth strings and your middle and ring fingers on the third and second

strings, respectively. Pull the second and third strings so they slap into the neck. Try a bit of compression.

Ex. 4 evokes the playing of Telemasters Albert Lee, Roy Nichols, and Ray Flacke. The first two notes are staccato, but don't play them too short. Be sure to accent the second-to-last note. You'll hear hot playing in a similar vein on Ricky Skaggs' "One Way Rider," Emmylou Harris' "Luxury Liner," and Roseanne Cash's "My Baby Thinks He's A Train."

Where would country guitar be without string bending? A classic example is Roy Nichols' intro to Merle Haggard's "Mama Tried" (**Ex. 5**). Make sure your bends are in tune; artful string benders dedicate countless hours to perfecting their intonation. You will probably notice improved accuracy in your blues bends after practicing country bends.

Real steel

Now let's look at some common pedal steel imitations. Bending the second scale degree into the third brings us into the top three notes of a familiar major barre chord (**Ex.**

Ex. 1a

G

Ex. 1b

G

Ex. 2

D Em A7 D

6a). The last harmony of **Ex. 6b** shifts the non-bent root and 5 down an octave. Sliding the root of the chord back a half-step creates *Dmaj7* (**Ex. 6c**—you'll be pulling this and the next four bends toward the floor); another half-step gives us a dominant-7th sound (**Ex. 6d**). Changing the 5 gives us *E7* (**Ex. 6e**) and *Gmaj7* (**Ex. 6f**). **Ex. 6g** illustrates an *A7-A13* change. Try injecting these into intros, endings, and chord-melody solos, and check out "I Can't Stop Lovin' You" from Arlen Roth's *Toolin' Around* (Blue Plate) for some great chord-melody fake-steel licks.

Sixths can be harmonized just as readily as thirds, and **Ex. 7** includes double-stops of both intervals. You can hear ideas like this on Dwight Yoakam's "Guitars, Cadillacs." This lick may be easier with the pick-and-finger technique.

Ex. 8 bends into the suspended 4th. This figure is most often played slowly, giving the suspension a chance to create some tension before its release. Experiment with harmonics by holding the pick with the middle finger and thumb and touching each string with the tip of your index finger 12 frets above the note your other hand is fretting. Swells from a volume knob or volume pedal add a nice touch.

Ex. 9 makes a great pick-and-finger exercise. Play it slowly before building to a relaxed, rolling tempo. The pick plays the fourth and third strings, while your middle finger plays the second string and your ring finger plays the first. Keep your fretting-hand pinky and ring finger down on the first and second strings, letting the notes sustain. This type of lick works great over bluegrass,

country, and half-time country-rock beats. Arlen Roth gets the credit for this one.

Cryin' time

A good accompaniment to **Ex. 9** is the "Foggy Mountain Breakdown" lick in **Ex. 10**. It was originally played on banjo, but we can simulate the effect with the pick-and-finger approach. The pick plays only the third string. When playing the three notes together, be sure the pick clears your middle and ring fingers to the neck side. Listen to Earl Scruggs, the Banjo Bandits, Buck Trent, and Roy Clark for more hot ideas.

Almost every Dobro, lap steel, and pedal steel guitarist plays some form of **Ex. 11**. Use a heavy vibrato for a crying, bluesy sound. With a light touch, let all notes sustain as long as possible.

Ex. 12 is another steel-type lick based on thirds. You can hear some of this flavor at the end of Merle Haggard's "Workin' Man Blues." In fact, this is one of the most clichéd country guitar licks. Pick the first two notes, but pluck the rest with your middle and ring fingers. Slap the strings into the fretboard for that chicken pickin' sound. ■

Ex. 3

D7



Ex. 4

C7



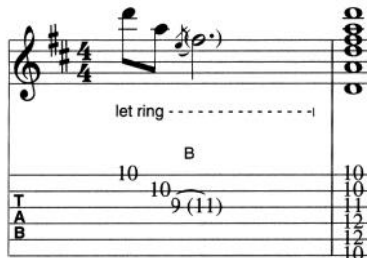
Ex. 5

D7



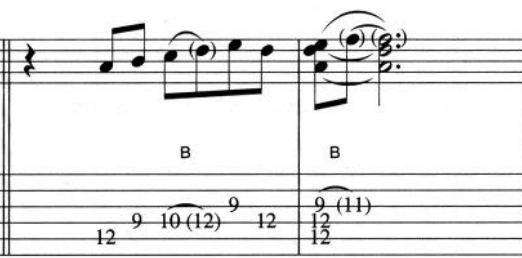
Ex. 6a

D



Ex. 6b

D



25 Country Licks

Ex. 6c

Dmaj7

T 9
A 11
B 12

Ex. 6d

D7

T 9
A 10
B 12

Ex. 6e

E7 (E9) E7

T 9
A 11
B 12

Ex. 6f

Gmaj7

T 9
A 11
B 12

Ex. 6g

A7 (A13) A7

T 9
A 11
B 12

Ex. 7

A

T 2 3 4 5
A 5 6 7 9(11) (11) (11)
B 6 6 7 9(11) (11) (11)

Ex. 8

A

T 6 (7) (7) 6
A 5 5
B 7 7 6 (7) 6

Ex. 9

G

T 0 2 0 0 2 0 0 2
A 3 3 3 3 3 3 3 3
B 2 (4) (4) (4) 2 0 3 0 3

Ex. 10

G

T 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0
A 3 3 3 3 3 3 3 3
B 2 3 2 3 2 3 2 3

Ex. 11

Ex. 11 is a guitar exercise in 4/4 time. The melody is in treble clef with a key signature of one sharp (F#). The bass lines are in tenor (T), alto (A), and bass (B) clefs. The exercise features a G major chord at the start, followed by a melodic line with triplets and a "let ring" instruction. The bass lines show fret numbers and string bends.

Ex. 12

Ex. 12 is a guitar exercise in 4/4 time. The melody is in treble clef with a key signature of one sharp (F#). The bass lines are in tenor (T), alto (A), and bass (B) clefs. The exercise features a melodic line with accents and a "let ring" instruction. The bass lines show fret numbers and string bends.

First Trip Wes

forms. Remember that Wes employed a variety of voicings, inversions, and substitutions, and often connected chords chromatically. **Ex. 11** shows a phrase over *Bm7-E7*. For an example of his chord-melody approach, check out "While We're Young," originally recorded on *So Much Guitar!* (Riverside).

Montgomery also had a very flexible sense of rhythm, although his intense drive aligned him stylistically with the hard-bop school more than any other. The accents in **Ex. 12** show how he might displace a four-note grouping by one eighth-note, while **Ex. 13** illustrates a four-note grouping in a triplet context. Try these ideas with your own lines.

In the final analysis, how Wes did something is secondary to what he did. "You can have multiple degrees in harmony and theory, be a tremendous reader, and have all kinds of technical skills," comments Steve Khan, "but in the end you have to *hear* something—especially in jazz. Wes heard something." ■